UnitedHealthcare Pharmacy
Clinical Pharmacy Programs

Program Number	2026 P 3044-18
Program	Step Therapy – Antidepressants
Medication/Therapeutic Class	Auvelity® (dextromethorphan/bupropion), Exxua™ (gepirone), Trintellix (vortioxetine) and Fetzima® (levomilnacipran)
P&T Approval Date	11/2014, 11/2015, 5/2016, 5/2017, 9/2017, 5/2018, 5/2019, 5/2020, 6/2021, 9/2022, 3/2023, 11/2023, 10/2024, 10/2025, 5/2026, 6/2026
Effective Date	9/1/2026

1. Background:

Step therapy type programs have been utilized to encourage use of lower cost alternatives for certain therapeutic classes. This program requires a trial of at least three step one medications before providing coverage for Auvelity, Exxua, Trintellix or Fetzima. Auvelity for agitation associated with dementia due to Alzheimer's Disease will not require step. If a member has three step one medications in claim's history in the previous 180 days then Auvelity, Exxua, Trintellix or Fetzima will automatically process. Members with a history of Auvelity, Exxua, Trintellix or Fetzima as documented in claims history will be allowed continued coverage of their current therapy. Members new to therapy will be required to meet the below criteria.

2. Coverage Criteria[a]:

Authorization

A. **Auvelity, Exxua, Trintellix** or **Fetzima** will be approved based upon **ONE** of the following:

1. History of failure after at least 4 weeks of therapy, contraindication, or intolerance to at least **THREE** of any formulation of the following (document drug and date of trials):

   a. bupropion
   b. citalopram
   c. duloxetine
   d. escitalopram
   e. fluoxetine
   f. fluvoxamine
   g. paroxetine
   h. sertraline
   i. venlafaxine IR/ER (capsules)

-OR-

2. The requested medication was initiated during a recent inpatient mental health hospitalization, and the member is stabilized on the requested medication

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-OR-

3. Member is new to the plan and currently stabilized on the requested medication (as evidenced by coverage effective date of less than or equal to 120 days)

-OR-

4. **Auvelity** is being requested for agitation associated with dementia due to Alzheimer's Disease

Authorization will be issued for 12 months.

[a] State mandates may apply. Any federal regulatory requirements and the member specific benefit plan coverage may also impact coverage criteria. Other policies and utilization management programs may apply.

3. Other Clinical Programs:

- Notwithstanding Coverage Criteria, UnitedHealthcare may approve initial and re-authorization based solely on previous claim/medication history, diagnosis codes (ICD-10) and/or claim logic. Use of automated approval and re-approval processes varies by program and/or therapeutic class.
- Supply limits may also be in place.

4. References:

1. Fetzima [package Insert]. North Chicago, IL: AbbVie, Inc.; April 2024.
2. Trintellix [package Insert]. Deerfield, IL: Takeda Pharmaceuticals, America; February 2025.
3. American Psychiatric Association Practice Guideline for the Treatment of Patient with Major Depressive Disorder, 3rd Edition. October 2010.
4. Auvelity [package insert]. New York, NY: Axsome Therapeutics, Inc.; May 2026.
5. Exxua [package insert]. San Antonio, TX: Aytu Therapeutics, LLC; July 2025.

Program	Step Therapy – Antidepressants
Change Control	
Date	Change
11/2014	New program.
11/2015	Updated references. Added Maryland Continuation of Care.
5/2016	Updated Brintellix name due to name change.
7/2016	Added Indiana and West Virginia coverage information.
11/2016	Administrative change. Added California coverage information.
5/2017	Annual review. Updated references. Added requirement to document duration of medication trial, in addition to the currently required name and date of the three medications previously tried. Removed reference to Trintellix's original name Brintellix. Updated state mandate reference language.

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9/2017	Added reauthorization criteria to allow for continuation of therapy. Added note for Trintellix exclusion.
5/2018	Removed note for Trintellix exclusion. Coverage restored.
5/2019	Revised documentation requirements. Added self-look back for auto adjudication.
5/2020	Updated references.
6/2021	Added documentation of first line drug tried. Updated references.
9/2022	Annual review. Updated references.
3/2023	Added Auvelity to program. Updated references.
11/2023	Updated references.
10/2024	Annual review. Updated references.
10/2025	Annual review. Updated references.
5/2026	Added Exxua to program. Updated references.
6/2026	Added Auvelity's new indication for agitation associated with dementia due to Alzheimer's Disease.

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